Political Discontent and Regime Instability

Put abstract here. And here.

Authors

- Haofeng Ma, ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0003-4379-8449, Ph.D. Candidate, Department of Political Science, University of Iowa, haofeng-ma@uiowa.edu
- Jeongho Choi, ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0002-8060-7907, Ph.D. Candidate, Department of Political Science, University of Iowa, jeongho-choi@uiowa.edu
- Yuehong Cassandra Tai, ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0001-7303-7443, Postdoctoral Fellow, Center for Social Data Analytics, Pennsylvania State University, yhcasstai@psu.edu
- Yue Hu, ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0002-2829-3971, Associate Professor, Department of Political Science, Tsinghua University, yuehu@tsinghua.edu.cn
- Frederick Solt, ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0002-3154-6132, Professor, Department of Political Science, University of Iowa, frederick-solt@uiowa.edu

Data Availability Statement

Replication data is available on the Harvard Dataverse [link tbd], and the work's complete revision history is available at https://github.com/fsolt/trust_stability.

Political Discontent and Regime Instability

abstract

Measuring Regime Instability

Jeongho will write it # Coauthor Guide – Findings & Framing {.unlisted .unnumbered}

❗ READ BEFORE DRAFTING – what the results are, what we can and cannot claim (JC, 2026-07-29; numbers = final full rerun)

TL;DR. Across ~170 model cells (four regime-event codings, two estimators, all with method-of-composition uncertainty propagation over 900 posterior draws), one sentence organizes the results:

> **Political discontent predicts regime instability only in non-democracies.** Discontent among publics in autocracies precedes both the *onset* of regime-change episodes and *completed democratization* under turnover-based codings (DD, BMR). In democracies it predicts nothing – not breakdown under any of the four codings, not even the onset of erosion episodes – contra the "discontent is killing democracy" narrative. (Secondary, support side: the Tai–Hu–Solt pattern extends to events – diffuse support is protective in democracies at the episode-onset stage, and does nothing for autocracies.)

This is the sentence the theory, introduction, and conclusion should be built around. Full results: Tables 1–4 and the battery figure below (Results section); every estimated model is in `output/tables_appendix_all_models.docx`.

Key numbers (MOC, final rerun). Episode onset, regime split (Table 2B): discontent in autocracies +.047–.048, p = .010/.021; support in democracies -.034/-.036, p = .011/.012; both cross-terms null (p = .50–.64). Draw-wise asymmetry tests: support p = .046/.049, discontent p = .062/.065. Completed transitions, democratization side (Table 3B/D): DD p = .033/.035, BMR p = .007/.010 (BMR within-coding asymmetry p = .010–.035 in all four cells); breakdown side null everywhere (p = .44–.83).

What we CAN claim.

1. Discontent precedes the *start* of regime-change processes, concentrated among publics in autocracies (Table 2, Panel B).
2. Discontent precedes *completed democratization* under turnover-based dichotomous codings (DD, BMR), with the democratization-vs-breakdown asymmetry formally significant in BMR.
3. Support protects democracies at the episode-onset stage (additive main effect).
4. Discontent does not predict democratic breakdown under any of the four codings, nor erosion-episode onset – a strong, multiply-operationalized null that speaks directly against the "discontent kills democracy" narrative.
5. Naive analysis overstates certainty: naive-significant cells die under MOC; the surviving claims are exactly those robust to measurement uncertainty.

What we must NOT claim (guardrails).

- No buffering / "critical citizens" conditional claims: the discontent-x-support interaction is directionally consistent but uniformly null under MOC (tested throughout; archived). Support's protection is *additive*.
- "Precedes democratization," not "causes democratization": observational 1-year-lead evidence. ERT completion cells are null – discontent knocks on the door; other forces open it.
- The completion result is **coding-conditional**: turnover-based dichotomies (DD, BMR) yes; ERT index-threshold transitions and GWF regime cases no. Not a contradiction – the event-overlap audit (Table 4) shows the codings share only ~25–45% of their "democratization" events. Say which definitions carry the result.

- Do not headline the pooled any-onset (all regimes) cell: it sits in a borderline band (MOC p = .035–.060) because it pools the strong autocratic signal with the null democratic one. The regime-split cell (Table 2, Panel B) is the main evidence.
- GWF cells and the liberalization-onset cell are exploratory (5–18 events). Regime-split GMM estimates but fails its own diagnostics (Sargan/AR(2)) in every instrument window probed – cautionary, appendix only.

Pointers per section.

- *Theory/framing*: mass opinion erodes the status-quo regime with regime-type-asymmetric consequences – Welzel-style aspirations push autocracies toward democracy; Easton/Claassen-style diffuse support keeps democracies from starting to erode. The two null cells are theoretically load-bearing: discontent does not kill democracies (contra Foa/Mounk), and popular support does not save autocracies.
- *Literature*: `paper/lit_review_regime_stability.md` is complete and web-verified – no opinion-IV study uses event DVs; none of the 18 canonical stability-DV studies includes mass opinion.
- *Introduction*: lead with the doom narrative, then report that the threat is real but points the other way – at autocracies.
- *Conclusion*: measurement matters twice – uncertainty propagation (naive vs MOC) and event definitions (the overlap audit); both are portable lessons.
- *Data/Methods/Results*: JC (drafted below). Numbers regenerate from `codes/final_01_master.R` (estimation) and `final_02`–`final_05` (tables/figure); do not hand-edit result numbers.

Literature

A test of citation (Claassen 2019; **?**).

Theory

Political Discontent and Regime (In)stability

Data and Measurement

0.1 Public political discontent and democratic support

Our focal predictor is public political discontent (PPD), the latent country-year estimate introduced in (**?**): a Bayesian latent-variable model (DCPO; (**?**)) that pools [N] survey items on political dissatisfaction across [K] countries. Because the estimates carry measurement uncertainty, we retain 900 draws from the posterior rather than point estimates. Democratic support is measured analogously with the Claassen-style support mood (**?**; **?**), also as 900 paired posterior draws. Both scales run 0–100. Country-years before a country's first actual survey are dropped (the published trim rule), removing backward extrapolation from the estimation sample. The analysis window is effectively 1988–2019, bounded by the survey base and the control series.

0.2 Regime-change outcomes

Our theory concerns regime change, not movements in democratic quality. We therefore measure outcomes as discrete regime events, and – because event codings embody consequential definitional choices – we use four canonical datasets rather than one:

1. **V-Dem ERT / Regimes of the World** (**?**): (a) *episode onset*, the first year of a democratization or autocratization episode (a sustained, substantial movement of the electoral-democracy index), with the risk set excluding ongoing-episode years; and (b) *category change*, any move among the four Regimes-of-the-World classes, including the democracy–autocracy boundary crossing.
2. **DD/ACLP** in the Bjornskov–Rode update (**?**), which extends Cheibub–Gandhi–Vreeland coverage to the mid-2020s: democratization and democratic breakdown on the contestation-plus-alternation dichotomy.
3. **Boix–Miller–Rosato** (**?**): the same two events on the Boix-lineage dichotomy (1800–2020).

4. **Geddes–Wright–Frantz** (**?**) regime cases (supplementary: coverage ends 2010, leaving 16 in-sample boundary events).

All events follow one convention: the event year is the **final year of the outgoing regime** (lead-coded where the source codes the new regime's first year), so that covariates measured in the event year precede the transition itself. Each coding contributes its own duration clock (its native regime-spell age) and its own transition-history control (the count of prior transitions under its own definition, which by construction never includes the event being modeled). As we document in the Results (Table 4), the codings capture substantially different event populations, which motivates the multi-coding design and disciplines interpretation.

0.3 Controls

The full specification carries nine controls: the five from Claassen's (2020) design (log GDP per capita, GDP growth, regional democracy levels, percent Muslim, resource dependence; the first two and the last are multiply imputed in the source, and the imputation draws are paired with the opinion draws), the two robust determinants from the extreme-bounds analysis of Gassebner, Lamla, and Vreeland (**?**) that the Claassen set lacks (prior transitions and OECD membership), plus income inequality (SWIID 9.8; (**?**)) and log population (World Bank).

Empirical Strategy

0.1 Propagating measurement uncertainty

Every model is estimated twice. The *naive* version uses posterior-mean data, as is standard practice. The *method-of-composition* (MOC) version re-estimates the model on each of the 900 draw-datasets, samples one coefficient vector from each fitted model's sampling distribution, and summarizes the resulting 900 draws: the point estimate is the draw mean and the standard error the draw standard deviation, so reported uncertainty combines sampling and measurement components (**?**; **?**). Interaction and derived quantities (marginal effects, slope differences) are computed draw-wise, preserving the

coefficient covariance. Products for the naive data are rebuilt from averaged components, since the mean of products is not the product of means.

0.2 Dynamic panel

To anchor the analysis in the existing literature we first estimate Claassen's (2020) specification with the democracy *level* as outcome:

$$D_{it} = \alpha + \sum_{k=1}^{2} \phi_k D_{i,t-k} + \beta\, \theta_{i,t-1} + \gamma\, S_{i,t-1} + \mathbf{X}_{i,t-1}\delta + \varepsilon_{it}$$

for V-Dem liberal and electoral democracy, by pooled OLS (panel-corrected standard errors) and system GMM (one-step, levels-and-differences), using Claassen's instrument lag window (3–5) with collapsed instrument columns – our panel is more complete than the original, so the uncollapsed set over-instruments (Sargan pinned at 1.000). A regime-split variant enters discontent and support as zero-filled interactions with a Regimes-of-the-World democracy dummy. The regime-split GMM variant is estimated for completeness but treated as cautionary only: its overidentification and serial-correlation tests reject in every instrument window probed, its lagged-DV coefficients imply explosive dynamics, and its coefficients flip sign across specifications – the signature of a misspecified mean equation rather than of any estimable effect (Appendix [X]).

0.3 Discrete-time hazards

Events are rare and binary, so persistence is handled by a duration baseline rather than lagged outcomes: we estimate discrete-time hazard logits with the coding's native regime age and its square, the coding's transition-history count, and the nine controls. Every cell is estimated by both plain maximum likelihood with country-clustered standard errors and Firth penalized likelihood (**?**); divergence between the two flags small-sample fragility, and we report both throughout. Timing follows a uniform one-year opinion-precedes-outcome rule: boundary-crossing events are lead-coded, so current-year covariates precede the transition; episode-onset events occur within the year, so the entire right-hand side is lagged one year.

Our central specification splits the opinion slopes by regime type within one pooled hazard. With $R_{i,t-1}$ an indicator for democracy (each coding's own classification for its

own cells),

$$\Pr(Y_{it}=1)=\Lambda(\beta_a\theta_{i,t-1}(1-R)+\beta_d\theta_{i,t-1}R+\gamma_a S_{i,t-1}(1-R)+\gamma_d S_{i,t-1}R+\lambda R+f(\text{age}_{it})+\mathbf{X}\delta)$$

This is the zero-filled full-interaction parameterization of the dynamic-panel literature transplanted to the hazard setting: regime-specific opinion slopes share one baseline hazard and one control block, which preserves events-per- variable in the rare-events cells, and – because both slopes sit in one model – permits a formal test of regime asymmetry as the draw-wise distribution of $\hat{\beta}_a - \hat{\beta}_d$.

Results

0.1 Public opinion does not move annual democracy levels

Table 1: Table 1. Public opinion and annual democracy-index change (dynamic panel, full specification). Coefficients x1000.

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
A. Liberal democracy (all regimes)	Discontent (t-1)	Pooled OLS	-0.042	(0.305)	-0.040	0.043	(0.355)	NA
A. Liberal democracy (all regimes)	Support (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.102**	(0.038)	0.078+	0.045	(0.083)	NA
A. Liberal democracy (all regimes)	Discontent (t-1)	System GMM	-0.034	(0.395)	-0.030	0.043	(0.488)	NA
A. Liberal democracy (all regimes)	Support (t-1)	System GMM	0.093	(0.122)	0.058	0.062	(0.348)	NA

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
B. Liberal democracy (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.066	(0.290)	0.057	0.064	(0.375)	NA
B. Liberal democracy (regime split)	Discontent in democracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	-0.066	(0.163)	-0.069	0.049	(0.156)	NA
B. Liberal democracy (regime split)	Support in autocracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.062	(0.394)	0.049	0.073	(0.501)	NA
B. Liberal democracy (regime split)	Support in democracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.097+	(0.062)	0.074	0.051	(0.143)	NA
B. Liberal democracy (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies (t-1)	System GMM (cautionary)	0.386+	(0.054)	0.391**	0.195	(0.045)	NA
B. Liberal democracy (regime split)	Discontent in democracies (t-1)	System GMM (cautionary)	-0.117	(0.461)	-0.122	0.160	(0.445)	NA
B. Liberal democracy (regime split)	Support in autocracies (t-1)	System GMM (cautionary)	0.051	(0.811)	0.090	0.200	(0.653)	NA
B. Liberal democracy (regime split)	Support in democracies (t-1)	System GMM (cautionary)	-0.735***	(0.006)	-0.612***	0.232	(0.008)	NA
C. Electoral democracy (all regimes)	Discontent (t-1)	Pooled OLS	-0.000	(0.998)	-0.009	0.051	(0.856)	NA
C. Electoral democracy (all regimes)	Support (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.102+	(0.061)	0.078	0.054	(0.149)	NA

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
C. Electoral democracy (all regimes)	Discontent (t-1)	System GMM	-0.007	(0.872)	-0.022	0.055	(0.688)	NA
C. Electoral democracy (all regimes)	Support (t-1)	System GMM	0.090	(0.130)	0.052	0.066	(0.430)	NA
D. Electoral democracy (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.060	(0.437)	0.050	0.078	(0.518)	NA
D. Electoral democracy (regime split)	Discontent in democracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	-0.022	(0.672)	-0.029	0.051	(0.570)	NA
D. Electoral democracy (regime split)	Support in autocracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.084	(0.345)	0.068	0.082	(0.412)	NA
D. Electoral democracy (regime split)	Support in democracies (t-1)	Pooled OLS	0.094+	(0.072)	0.069	0.052	(0.185)	NA
D. Electoral democracy (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies (t-1)	System GMM (cautionary)	0.077	(0.697)	0.149	0.199	(0.452)	NA
D. Electoral democracy (regime split)	Discontent in democracies (t-1)	System GMM (cautionary)	-0.441**	(0.027)	-0.399**	0.193	(0.038)	NA
D. Electoral democracy (regime split)	Support in autocracies (t-1)	System GMM (cautionary)	0.080	(0.728)	0.116	0.240	(0.629)	NA

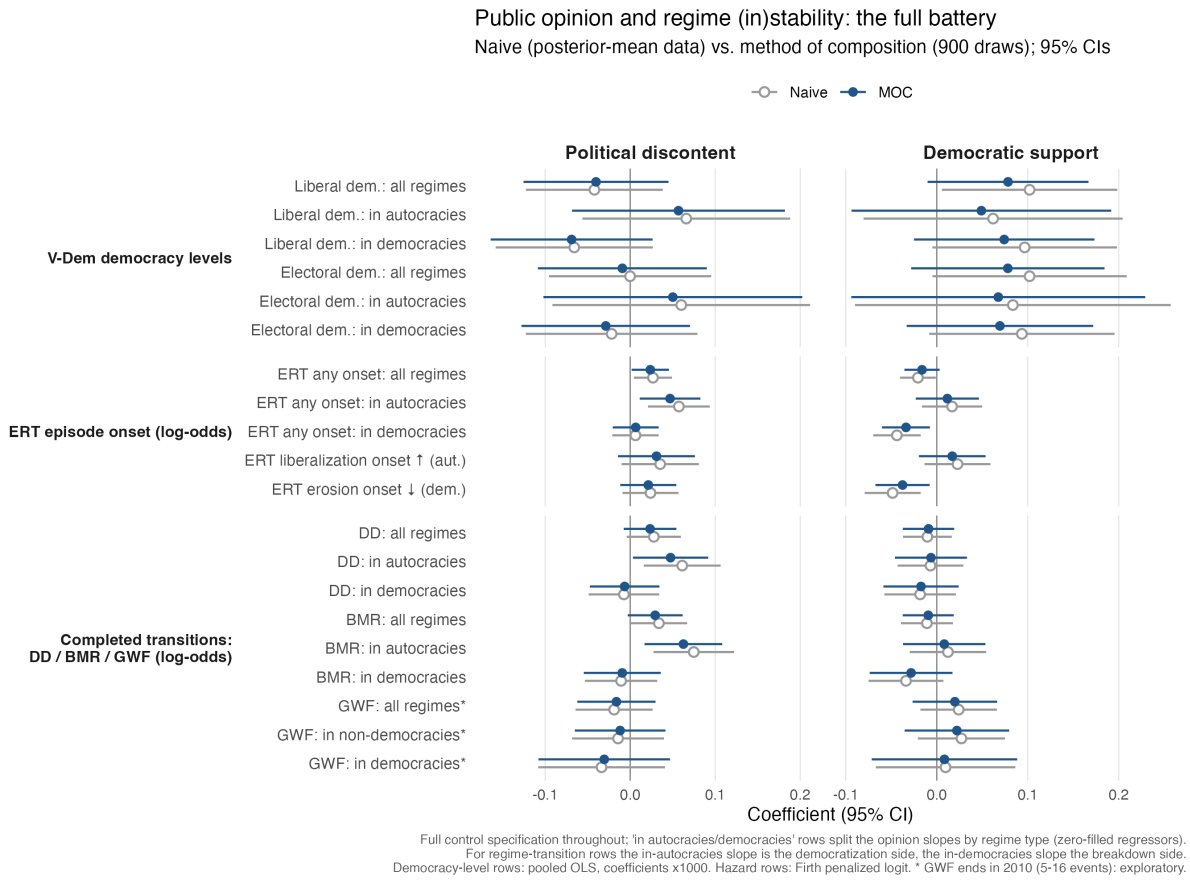


Figure 1: The full battery at a glance: focal coefficients with 95% confidence intervals, naive (posterior-mean data, open grey) vs. method of composition (900 draws, solid blue). Top: pooled-OLS democracy-level models with regime-split opinion slopes (x1000). Middle: ERT episode-onset hazards (split IVs, Firth). Bottom: completed democracy-boundary crossings under DD/BMR/GWF (split IVs, Firth; GWF exploratory, coverage ends 2010).

D. Electoral democracy (regime split)	Support in democracies (t-1)	System GMM (cautionary)	0.889***	- 0.730**	(0.005)	- 0.286	(0.011)	NA	

Table 1 reports the dynamic-panel results. Discontent is null in every valid cell (MOC $p = .16$–$.86$). Support reproduces the pattern documented by (**?**): naive-significant in pooled OLS ($p = .04$–$.06$), attenuating to marginal or null once measurement uncertainty is propagated ($p = .08$–$.50$). Under the full specification, no opinion variable robustly predicts year-to-year movement in democracy indices. If public opinion matters for regimes, it does not operate through marginal annual changes in democratic quality – motivating the shift to discrete regime events.

0.2 Discontent starts regime-change episodes – in autocracies

Table 2: Table 2. Public opinion and the onset of V-Dem ERT regime-change episodes (discrete-time hazard, full specification). Log-odds per point of the 0-100 opinion scales.

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
A. ERT any onset (all regimes)	Discontent (t-1)	Logit	0.027**	(0.040)	0.024+	0.013	(0.060)	90
A. ERT any onset (all regimes)	Discontent (t-1)	Firth	0.027**	(0.019)	0.024**	0.011	(0.035)	90
A. ERT any onset (all regimes)	Support (t-1)	Logit	- 0.021**	(0.039)	- 0.016+	0.010	(0.097)	90
A. ERT any onset (all regimes)	Support (t-1)	Firth	- 0.021**	(0.039)	- 0.016	0.010	(0.102)	90
B. ERT any onset (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies (t-1)	Logit	0.059***	(0.005)	0.048**	0.021	(0.021)	90

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
B. ERT any onset (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies (t-1)	Firth	0.057***	(0.002)	0.047**	0.018	(0.010)	90
B. ERT any onset (regime split)	Discontent in democracies (t-1)	Logit	0.007	(0.644)	0.007	0.014	(0.614)	90
B. ERT any onset (regime split)	Discontent in democracies (t-1)	Firth	0.006	(0.655)	0.006	0.014	(0.640)	90
B. ERT any onset (regime split)	Support in autocracies (t-1)	Logit	0.017	(0.318)	0.012	0.018	(0.504)	90
B. ERT any onset (regime split)	Support in autocracies (t-1)	Firth	0.017	(0.320)	0.012	0.018	(0.510)	90
B. ERT any onset (regime split)	Support in democracies (t-1)	Logit	-0.045***	(0.002)	-0.036**	0.014	(0.012)	90
B. ERT any onset (regime split)	Support in democracies (t-1)	Firth	-0.044***	(0.001)	-0.034**	0.013	(0.011)	90
C. ERT any onset (autocracies subsample)	Discontent (t-1)	Logit	0.041**	(0.040)	0.033+	0.020	(0.092)	32
C. ERT any onset (autocracies subsample)	Discontent (t-1)	Firth	0.038**	(0.047)	0.031	0.019	(0.108)	32
C. ERT any onset (autocracies subsample)	Support (t-1)	Logit	0.003	(0.889)	0.001	0.019	(0.959)	32
C. ERT any onset (autocracies subsample)	Support (t-1)	Firth	0.002	(0.900)	0.001	0.017	(0.939)	32

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
D. ERT any onset (democracies subsample)	Discontent (t-1)	Logit	0.018	(0.348)	0.016	0.019	(0.394)	58
D. ERT any onset (democracies subsample)	Discontent (t-1)	Firth	0.017	(0.227)	0.016	0.014	(0.268)	58
D. ERT any onset (democracies subsample)	Support (t-1)	Logit	-0.048***	(0.004)	-0.037**	0.015	(0.017)	58
D. ERT any onset (democracies subsample)	Support (t-1)	Firth	-0.046***	(0.001)	-0.036**	0.014	(0.010)	58
E. ERT liberalization onset (up) (autocracies subsample)	Discontent (t-1)	Logit	0.040+	(0.056)	0.033	0.025	(0.172)	18
E. ERT liberalization onset (up) (autocracies subsample)	Discontent (t-1)	Firth	0.035	(0.128)	0.031	0.023	(0.182)	18
E. ERT liberalization onset (up) (autocracies subsample)	Support (t-1)	Logit	0.025	(0.248)	0.018	0.021	(0.381)	18
E. ERT liberalization onset (up) (autocracies subsample)	Support (t-1)	Firth	0.023	(0.218)	0.017	0.019	(0.364)	18
F. ERT erosion onset (down) (democracies subsample)	Discontent (t-1)	Logit	0.025	(0.208)	0.021	0.019	(0.268)	42
F. ERT erosion onset (down) (democracies subsample)	Discontent (t-1)	Firth	0.024	(0.154)	0.021	0.017	(0.206)	42
F. ERT erosion onset (down) (democracies subsample)	Support (t-1)	Logit	-0.050***	(0.006)	-0.039**	0.017	(0.020)	42

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
F. ERT erosion onset (down) (democracies subsample)	Support (t-1)	Firth	- 0.049***	(0.002)	- 0.038**	0.015	(0.014)	42

Table 2, Panel B contains the paper's central estimates. Among publics in autocracies, discontent measured at $t-1$ raises the hazard that a regime-change episode begins at t: the MOC estimate is .047–.048 log-odds per scale point ($p = .010/.021$ by Firth and plain logit respectively) – roughly a **70% increase in the odds of episode onset per standard deviation of discontent** (11.6 points). The same quantity for publics in democracies is precisely zero ($p = .61$–$.64$). Support shows the mirror image: protective among publics in democracies (odds ratio per SD ≈ 0.67; $p = .011/.012$), null among publics in autocracies. The formal asymmetry tests confirm the pattern: the support asymmetry is significant ($p = .046/.049$), the discontent asymmetry marginal ($p = .062/.065$), in both estimators.

Panels C and D re-estimate the any-onset hazard within each regime subsample (single pooled slope, own baseline and controls): directionally consistent with the split estimates, at conventional significance only where events are plentiful. Panels E and F probe direction. The liberalization-onset cell (autocracies only, 18 events) is directionally positive but underpowered. The erosion-onset cell (democracies, 42 events) is the doom narrative's best chance to appear – discontent predicting the *start* of democratic erosion – and it is null ($p = .21$–$.27$), while support's protective effect persists ($p = .014$–$.020$).

0.3 Discontent precedes completed democratization – under turnover-based codings

Table 3: Table 3. Public opinion and completed regime transitions across canonical codings (discrete-time hazard, split IVs, full specification). Log-odds.

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive se	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
A. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes)	Discontent	Logit	0.030	(0.119)	0.025	0.019	(0.191)	36	
A. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes)	Discontent	Firth	0.028+	(0.087)	0.023	0.016	(0.140)	36	
A. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes)	Support	Logit	-0.010	(0.562)	-0.009	0.018	(0.624)	36	
A. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes)	Support	Firth	-0.010	(0.452)	-0.009	0.014	(0.529)	36	
B. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies	Logit	0.066**	(0.010)	0.053**	0.025	(0.033)	36	
B. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies	Firth	0.061**	(0.008)	0.048**	0.023	(0.035)	36	
B. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in democracies	Logit	-0.006	(0.785)	-0.005	0.024	(0.830)	36	
B. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in democracies	Firth	-0.007	(0.727)	-0.007	0.021	(0.754)	36	
B. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in autocracies	Logit	-0.006	(0.779)	-0.006	0.021	(0.762)	36	
B. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in autocracies	Firth	-0.007	(0.707)	-0.006	0.020	(0.753)	36	
B. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in democracies	Logit	-0.019	(0.436)	-0.017	0.025	(0.489)	36	
B. DD regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in democracies	Firth	-0.018	(0.361)	-0.017	0.021	(0.411)	36	
C. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes)	Discontent	Logit	0.036**	(0.045)	0.030+	0.018	(0.099)	31	
C. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes)	Discontent	Firth	0.034**	(0.046)	0.029+	0.016	(0.074)	31	

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
C. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes)	Support	Logit	-0.011	(0.535)	-0.009	0.016	(0.569)	31
C. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes)	Support	Firth	-0.011	(0.459)	-0.009	0.014	(0.513)	31
D. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies	Logit	0.080***	(0.002)	0.070***	0.027	(0.010)	31
D. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in autocracies	Firth	0.075***	(0.002)	0.063***	0.023	(0.007)	31
D. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in democracies	Logit	-0.010	(0.682)	-0.008	0.024	(0.739)	31
D. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Discontent in democracies	Firth	-0.011	(0.622)	-0.009	0.023	(0.685)	31
D. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in autocracies	Logit	0.013	(0.561)	0.009	0.024	(0.713)	31
D. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in autocracies	Firth	0.012	(0.566)	0.008	0.023	(0.722)	31
D. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in democracies	Logit	-0.035	(0.247)	-0.031	0.029	(0.284)	31
D. BMR regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split)	Support in democracies	Firth	-0.034	(0.107)	-0.028	0.023	(0.224)	31
E. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes; exploratory)	Discontent	Logit	-0.019	(0.508)	-0.015	0.028	(0.576)	16
E. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes; exploratory)	Discontent	Firth	-0.019	(0.414)	-0.016	0.024	(0.490)	16
E. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes; exploratory)	Support	Logit	0.028	(0.301)	0.024	0.029	(0.413)	16

Model	Variable	Estimator	Naive b	Naive p	MOC b	MOC se	MOC p	Events
E. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (all regimes; exploratory)	Support	Firth	0.024	(0.261)	0.020	0.024	(0.401)	16
F. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Discontent in non-democracies	Logit	-0.013	(0.728)	-0.008	0.036	(0.827)	16
F. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Discontent in non-democracies	Firth	-0.014	(0.604)	-0.012	0.027	(0.664)	16
F. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Discontent in democracies	Logit	-0.034	(0.460)	-0.027	0.047	(0.568)	16
F. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Discontent in democracies	Firth	-0.034	(0.376)	-0.030	0.040	(0.441)	16
F. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Support in non-democracies	Logit	0.032	(0.225)	0.027	0.032	(0.405)	16
F. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Support in non-democracies	Firth	0.027	(0.267)	0.022	0.029	(0.450)	16
F. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Support in democracies	Logit	0.012	(0.860)	0.011	0.062	(0.860)	16
F. GWF regime transition (dem vs auto) (regime split; exploratory)	Support in democracies	Firth	0.010	(0.805)	0.008	0.041	(0.836)	16

Table 3 applies the same split design to each coding's own democracy boundary. The democratization-side slope – discontent among publics in autocracies – survives MOC un-

der both dichotomous codings: DD ($p = .033$–$.035$) and BMR ($p = .007$–$.010$), the latter implying that a standard-deviation increase in discontent roughly **doubles the odds** that an autocracy completes a transition to democracy the following year. The breakdown-side slope is null in every coding ($p = .44$–$.83$), and the within-coding asymmetry test is significant in all four BMR cells ($p = .010$–$.035$). GWF, with 16 in-sample boundary events and coverage ending in 2010, shows nothing and is treated as exploratory.

Two qualifications discipline this result. First, it is coding-conditional: ERT's own boundary-crossing cells are null. The next subsection shows why this is not a contradiction. Second, the ERT severity gradient – onset significant, completion null – indicates that discontent's reliable footprint is at the *initiation* of regime change; whether initiated episodes complete depends on downstream forces our design does not model.

0.4 Different codings count different democratizations

Table 4: Table 4. Event overlap across codings, survey-covered sample. Cell entries: captured/eligible (%) – row-coding events with a counterpart in the column coding (same country, event years within +/-2). Eligible excludes row events outside the column coding's coverage window; only GWF binds (ends 2010, so its column counts row events through 2012).

Event	Coding	Events	Captured by ERT	Captured by DD	Captured by BMR	Captured by GWF
Democratization	ERT	35	–	9/35 (26%)	6/35 (17%)	3/24 (12%)
Democratization	DD	25	9/25 (36%)	–	6/25 (24%)	8/18 (44%)
Democratization	BMR	18	6/18 (33%)	6/18 (33%)	–	5/12 (42%)
Democratization	GWF	12	3/12 (25%)	8/12 (67%)	5/12 (42%)	–
Breakdown	ERT	35	–	8/35 (23%)	6/35 (17%)	2/20 (10%)
Breakdown	DD	22	8/22 (36%)	–	10/22 (45%)	4/10 (40%)
Breakdown	BMR	18	6/18 (33%)	10/18 (56%)	–	4/10 (40%)
Breakdown	GWF	6	2/6 (33%)	4/6 (67%)	4/6 (67%)	–

Why does discontent predict completed democratization under DD and BMR but not under ERT's boundary crossing? Because, to a degree rarely acknowledged, the four series are not alternative measurements of one event list – they are substantially different event

lists. Table 4 makes this concrete: within the survey-covered sample, pairwise capture rates among the three democratization series run from 17% to 36%, and the breakdown side looks no better (17–56%). Even allowing a two-year dating window, roughly two of every three events in any one series have no counterpart in another.

The mismatches are systematic, not noise. Democratizations that only ERT records are predominantly index-threshold reclassifications within already-electoral regimes – countries crossing the electoral-autocracy / electoral-democracy line without a government turnover (e.g., Ukraine 2005, Kenya 2012, Mexico 1995, North Macedonia 2016). Democratizations that only the dichotomies record are turnover-type transitions – founding or alternation elections – where V-Dem's regime classification either had already moved or did not move within the window (e.g., Kyrgyzstan 2005, Thailand 2007, Taiwan 1999, Tunisia 2014). Read against Table 3, the pattern is informative rather than embarrassing: **public discontent precedes the turnover-type transitions that dichotomous codings are built to capture, not the incremental reclassifications that index thresholds register.** It also strengthens the breakdown null: discontent fails to predict democratic breakdown across three largely *distinct* event populations, not one list counted three ways.

0.5 What does not appear

Three null results are load-bearing. (1) **Democratic breakdown**: discontent predicts breakdown under none of the four codings, in no specification, by either estimator – and, per Table 2F, does not even predict the onset of erosion episodes. (2) **Conditional (buffering) effects**: the discontent-x-support interaction, estimated across the dynamic panel and the hazard battery, is directionally consistent with the critical-citizens hypothesis but never significant under MOC; support's protection should be read as additive, not conditional. (3) **Naive certainty**: across the battery, naive estimation produces significance that MOC extinguishes; every claim above survives uncertainty propagation, and several claims a naive analysis would have made do not.

Summary and Discussion

Reference

Claassen, Christopher. 2019. "Estimating Smooth Country–Year Panels of Public Opinion." *Political Analysis* 27 (1): 1–20.

———. 2020. "Does Public Support Help Democracy Survive?" *American Journal of Political Science* 64 (1): 118–34.

Political Discontent and Regime Instability

Online Supplementary Materials

Table of contents

Measuring Regime Instability **1**

0.1 Public political discontent and democratic support 4
0.2 Regime-change outcomes 4
0.3 Controls 5
0.1 Propagating measurement uncertainty 5
0.2 Dynamic panel 6
0.3 Discrete-time hazards 6
0.1 Public opinion does not move annual democracy levels 7
0.2 Discontent starts regime-change episodes – in autocracies 11
0.3 Discontent precedes completed democratization – under turnover-based codings 14
0.4 Different codings count different democratizations 18
0.5 What does not appear 19

References

Claassen, Christopher. 2019. "Estimating Smooth Country–Year Panels of Public Opinion." *Political Analysis* 27 (1): 1–20.